ties: physical fitness, navigation skills and riding skills. In terms of fitness and navigation, Noah believes he is up there with the best. "I need to get better at my riding skills," he says. Noah competes with athletes who begin riding as early as age 3; Indian riders begin late. That is changing, Sumbly says: "With MotoGP coming to India, motorsports is now a viable career."

Noah did enjoy a secret advantage at the Dakar, held since 2020 in Saudi Arabia, which has a sizeable Malayali population. For example, the company running the ambulance service is from Kerala. They took good care last year after he crashed and fractured his spine. This year, they were there to help during the stopovers.

When he reached Kerala two days after his victory, there was a crowd waiting to felicitate him at the airport. Noah felt shy. Winning at the Dakar is easy. Handling all the attention? That requires a skill Harith Noah doesn't possess. ■

–Sopan Joshi



CYCLING

PEDAL POWER

LIEUTENANT COLONEL BHARAT PANNU HAS NOTCHED UP YET ANOTHER WIN IN THE SELF-SUPPORTED CATEGORY OF THE ULTRA SPICE RACE

The doubts started creeping into Bharat Pannu's head on the third day of the Ultra Spice Race—a 1,750-km ultra cycling endeavour that got underway on January 22 from Bogmalo Beach in Goa, headed towards Ooty, before making its way back to the starting point. He had ridden about a thousand kilometres until then, solo and self-supported. But now, pedalling in the wee hours of the morning around Kalpetta in Kerala, he didn't see the sense of the entire effort. "The next cyclist was trailing me by a good distance. It breaks you down mentally because riding solo is one thing, but riding without competition makes things really difficult," says Pannu, who is 41.

It was a race he had won twice before. Yet, he persevered with the effort, slow and steady, while taking stock of the situation. And after 112 hours and 53 minutes, he picked up his third win in the self-supported category over the last five editions of the race.

Pannu broke down the mammoth distance into 16 sections. His aim was simply to get faster than his previous times on each one of them. Every time he managed it, he would indulge in extra rest to let the body recover. The constant mental calculations and the joy of thriving in his own company kept loneliness at bay. "A good indicator for me was the final 340 km to the finish. Anyone who has done it knows how monotonous this stretch gets after four days of riding. I was able to bring down my time on this section by almost four hours," says Pannu.

The ride was part of his preparation for the Race Across America (RAAM)—a 3,000-mile race that runs from the west to the east coast of the United States. In 2019, he suffered a broken collar bone during a training ride and returned home; in 2022, he finished 80 per cent of the distance before a fever forced him to abandon it. A lieutenant colonel in the Indian Army, Pannu has been training for RAAM since September. "A race like Ultra Spice is a reality check. A good performance gives you the confidence to do well in bigger races. I started my ultra cycling journey in 2017 and have grown as a rider. And I feel ready for my RAAM attempt come June," he says. ■

–Shail Desai

The Ultra Spice was part of **PANNU'S** preparation for the Race Across America, a 3,000-mile race from the west to the east coast of the US



ANAY DESHPANDE